Alan Keown

Festival of the New Sun

for percussion ensemble



Festival of the New Sun by Alan Keown
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TSPCE-65

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Program Notes

Festival of the New Sun (sometimes referred to as the "Unconquered Sun") was not originally an official festival but was celebrated by adherents to Mithraism as the birth of the new sun. The Emperor Aurelian was devoted to a single sun god (Sol Invictus), and during his reign it became a public festival complete with chariot racing in the Circus. He erected a temple to Sol Invictus in A.D. 274.

From an astrological standpoint, the sun is at its lowest aspect at the winter solstice. The earth is cold, most plants are dead, and it was believed that the sun might also be approaching death. The Romans celebrated the sun overcoming the power of Winter, with the hope of Spring when life would be renewed. Thus, the Feast and Festival of Sol Invicta, the Unconquered Sun, on December 25.

Performance Notes

1) The mallets for the timpani should be a hard felt-type mallet.

2) The cowbells should be mounted to allow maximum resonance.

3) The recommended setup should create a slightly antiphonal effect. This may make it more difficult to line up the rhythms player to player, but the effect will be worth the extra effort.

4) Dynamics should be strictly adhered to, especially the lower dynamics so the piece is not just loud throughout.

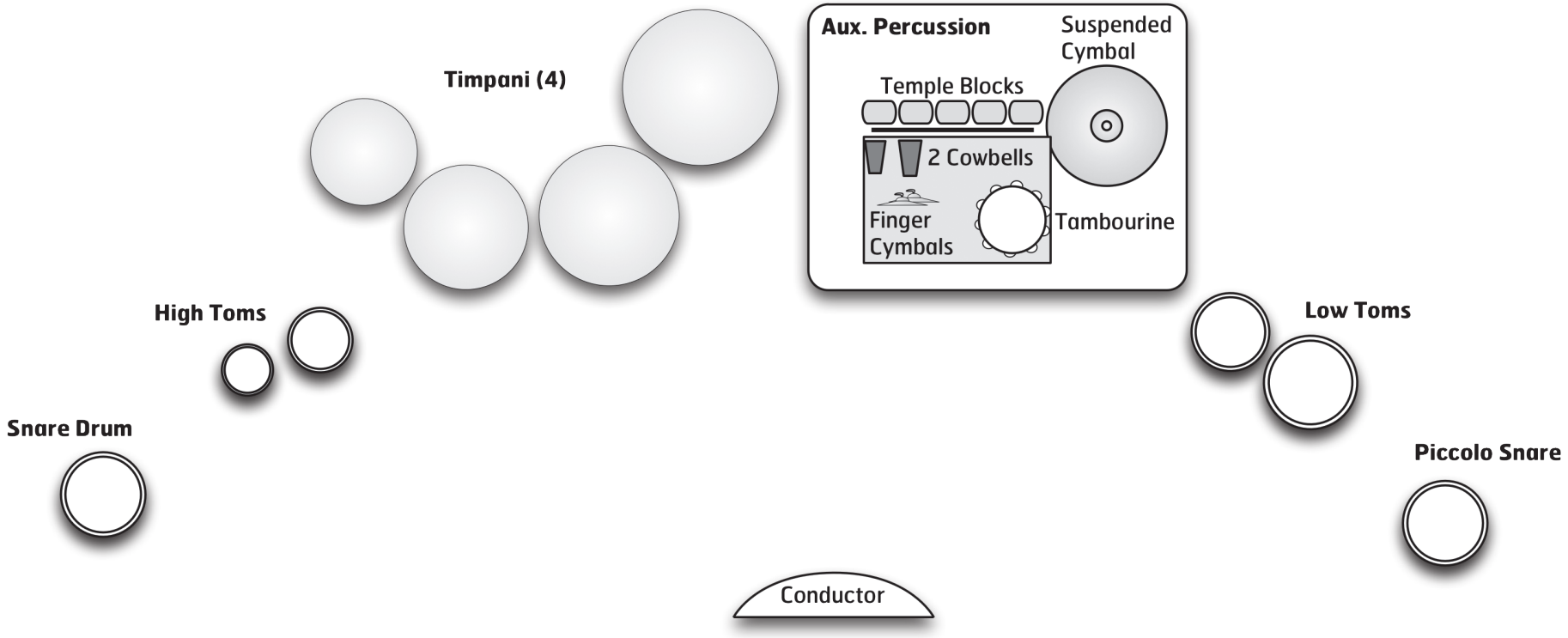
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Players and Instrumentation

Festival of the New Sun requires **6 players** with the following instrumentation:

- **1 snare drum**
- **2 toms (high)**
- **2 toms (low)**
- **1 piccolo snare drum**
- **Auxiliary percussion** (finger cymbals, 2 cowbells, tambourine, suspended cymbal, temple blocks)
- **4 timpani** (32", 29", 26", 23")

Suggested Setup



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Level: Med-Easy
Approx. playing time: 3'20""

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